

Colorado Field Ornithologists Sight Record Form
(Please print or type. Attach photographs and additional pages if necessary.)

(A)

2002-115

rec'd
11/16/03

Each table cell will automatically enlarge as you type!

CBRC FILE #:		
RESULTS:		
Species: (Common Name) Eastern Towhee		(Scientific Name) Pipilo erythrophthalmus
Date(s) of occurrence: January 03, 2003		
Number of birds seen: 1	Sex: Female	Plumage: Adult
Exact location: ¼ mile south of John Martin Reservoir near where Road 19 ends north of Road CC		
County: Bent	Nearest town: Las Animas	Elevation: approximately 3900
Length of observation: 45 minutes		Time(s) of observation: 11:00 am
Other observers who saw the bird(s) with you: Andrew Spencer		
Other observers who independently saw the bird(s): Tony Leukering, Chris Wood, Duane Nelson		
Light conditions (quality; direction relative to bird(s) and observers position: thin overcast, bird was in shaded area, observation was made from the north, looking south		
Optical equipment used: Nikon Superior E (8x32), Swarovski ATS 65, with 30x fixed eyepiece, photographed with Canon G2 digital		
Distance to bird(s) (estimated, unless otherwise noted): 25 feet		
Was (were) bird(s) photographed? yes		If so, are you submitting photos? yes
Who took the photograph(s)? Glenn Walbek		
Describe the general and specific habitats in which the bird(s) occurred: Rocky outcroppings covered on the north side by scrubby plants and grasses. Outcroppings located near prairie grass and reservoir with riparian habitat		
Describe the bird's (birds') behaviors, particularly behaviors that were used in supporting the identification, e.g., flying, feeding, habits: Foraging on ground using rocks and shrubs for cover. Occasionally flying to perch in low shrubs, and disappearing in rocks.		
DESCRIPTION -- This is the most important part of this report. Include in these details the overall size and shape of the bird, how you placed the bird in the general group that you did, and give as many plumage details as possible, even including those that you feel might not have relevance to the specific identification. Features to include are the color(s) and/or patterns of the head, eyes, bill, back, folded wings, open wings, tail, chin, throat, breast, sides, flanks, belly, vent, and legs. Also, please include, where possible, shape of the whole bird, of the wings – folded or open, of the bill, and of the tail. Please fill out this portion even if photos are accompanying your report. We welcome attachments of additional sheets of description, drawings, field sketches, or copies of field notes.		
The bird was towhee sized (8 to 9 inches), and shaped as compared with Spotted Towhee and Canyon Towhee also present during the observation. She was chunky with thick neck and large head. The bird was uniform chocolate brown above (head, throat, upper breast, nape, back, scapulars and remiges, and wing coverts) with rufous flanks and sides, and white lower breast and belly. Sharp delineation between brown upper breast and white lower breast giving the appearance of a brown hood. The folded tertials showed white edging resembling elongated spots. A thin, elongated white spot was noted on the base of the outside primary, as seen in the folded wing. The white elongated spots appeared as a few narrow streaks rather than extensive patterned spots of Spotted Towhee. The undertail coverts were pale rufous, while the undertail was dark (blackish) to midpoint, and white beyond the midpoint with dark protruding into the center portion of the white. The tail was long tail (3.5 inches estimated). Her bill was large and heavy (finch like) with curved upper and de-curve lower mandible. The legs were pale pink.		
Describe the bird's (birds') call(s) and/or song(s), if noted: none noted		
SIMILAR SPECIES – This is another critical part of your report. Please discuss how you eliminated similar species from consideration: Spotted Towhee is similar, subject bird however lacked extensive white spotting on scapulars, wing coverts and tertials. Color of subject bird was chocolate brown above with dark (not bright red iris).		
What is your prior experience with this and similarly appearing species? Have viewed and studied Eastern Towhee on numerous occasions in the eastern states. Spotted Towhee occurs in most of the habitat I bird in along the front range.		
List books, guides, recordings, or other sources consulted and how this influenced your identification (during and after observation): The Sibley guide to birds.		
This report was made from (check one) ☐ notes made during observation ☒ notes made after observation ☐ later from memory.		
Date and time of written report: January 13, 2003		Signature: 
Reporting observer's address: 10880 Parker Vista Road		
City: Parker	State: Colorado	Zip: 80138

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

(A)

NEW STATE RECORD _____ UNUSUAL RECORD X

rec'd 8/11/03

Species: Eastern Towhee (*Pipilo erythrophthalmus*)**Date:** 16 March 2003**Number seen:** one**Sex:** female**Plumage:** adult**Locality:** south side of John Martin Reservoir**Elevation:** about 3851'**Nearest town:** Caddoa**County:** Bent**Time observed:** early morning**Duration of observation:** a total of about 15 minutes**Description:**

Very similar in overall size, structure, and behavior to the more common Spotted Towhee (*P. maculatus*) found in Colorado. In strong contrast to Spotted, however, this bird had smooth, medium brown upperparts and lacked any spotting on the wings or scapulars. The brown extended as a hood from the upper chest, completely encompassing the head, including the upperparts to the tail (which had large, white spots on the outer rectrices), as well as the wings. Underparts were white, except for the deep robin orange sides and flanks. The undertail coverts and vent region were a lighter shade of orange than the sides/flanks. The only other plumage features noted were buffy edges to the tertials, and a white line mid-shaft down the primaries on the folded wing. The bill was dark. Legs were pale pink. Eyes were a dull red.

The bird skulked around in the underbrush near where bird seed was put out on the ground. It came into the open only a couple of times, and then very briefly.

Separation from similar species:

Complete lack of "spotting" on the upperparts eliminates Spotted Towhee. I don't think this bird was a hybrid as I assume that such an individual would show intermediate characteristics, particularly traces (or more) of white on the wings and scapulars, as well as grayer upperparts. The Sibley guide shows Eastern having a large white patch at the base of the primaries. I did not note that feature on this bird, nor do the photos show it. However, I'm not convinced that a lack of this feature is enough to put a hybrid tag on this bird without other, more obvious, Spotted characteristics also exhibited.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): I heard none.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing species? I lived most of my life in the East, but can't really say that I studied this common species, nor Spotted Towhee while I have been in Colorado.

Light conditions: slightly overcast with sun low and behind bird

Optical equipment used: Kowa scope 20x60 zoom, Zeiss 7x42

Distance, and how estimated: estimated closest distance at 10 meters

Other observers who saw the bird with you: Elena Thomas

Other observers who saw the bird independently: multiple observers. First found by Duane Nelson on 7 December 2002.

If photographed, type of equipment and film: Nikon Coolpix 4500 (digital) through scope

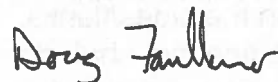
List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: none

b) after observation: National Audubon Society's *The Sibley Guide to Birds* and *The Sparrows of the United States and Canada* by James Rising. Used them while reviewing the photos. Not much info on hybrids though.

Reporting observer: Doug Faulkner

Signature:



Address: Rocky Mountain Bird Observatory, 14500 Lark Bunting Lane, Brighton, CO 80603

Date report was written: This report was written on 15 April 2003 from photos and memory.

